with the India army in Charar-e-Sharif, a small town in Kashmir's Budgam district. The standoff resulted in total devastation of the town and the burning of the sacred Sufi shrine of Charar-e-Sharif. Worst of all, Mast Gul escaped the scene and reappeared in Rawalpindi a few days later, where he received a hero's welcome.[95] Apart from unleashing a storm in the parliament (mostly on how Rao had proven incompetent on Kashmir as well as Pakistan, among his other failures) the Charar-e-Sharif incident concretised the notion of the Afghan Mujahideen's involvement in Kashmir. C D Sahay, former chief of R&AW (2003–05), and an expert on Kashmir and Pakistan, acknowledges: 'Around 1995, there was a view in Kashmir that the ISI had started inducting Taliban and Afghan Jihadis into Kashmir, particularly in Doda/Kishtawar area. Local verification however, revealed that the new group of militants were battle-hardened Pakistani mercenaries relieved of Jihadi duties in Afghanistan.'[96] Because Mast Gul was a Pashtun, the fact that he was a Pakistani national and not Afghan, had been overlooked during those tense moments. Targeting Rao's conciliatory approach, CPI leader Biplab Dasgupta wanted New Delhi to put pressure on both Pakistan and Afghanistan's Mujahideen government and ask why their militants were infiltrating Kashmir and what efforts they were making to curb these activities.[97] Jagmohan Malhotra, former governor of Kashmir (1990), known mostly by his mononym Jagmohan, also criticised the government for not being able to stop Hizb-ul-Mujahideen's visibly 'Afghan' looking men from infiltrating the shrine and planting explosives in there.[98]

The fact was, that most of these 'Afghan looking men', like Mast Gul, came from Pakistan's tribal regions while feeding into Indian officials' cultural generalisation that Pashtuns were Afghans. Despite knowing that it was the ISI that had built training camps for the HM under its covert K-2 programme (run by Brig. (Retd.) Imtiaz and supported by Brig. 'Badam'), where it was training fighters for Kashmir and Punjab, many (though not all) Indian officials began viewing the Afghan Mujahideen through a Kashmir-centric lens.[99] Reports had been pouring from early 1993 that some Afghan nationals had crossed the LoC to join HM militants in Kashmir. This number, however, was a meager twenty-five to thirty over a period of seven to eight months beginning November 1992.[100] Most of these were private individuals who had been recruited to join